

Communication Hardware Setup

The first step is to set up your communication hardware. We're talking about the microphone and the webcam. Some gamers prefer not to use a webcam while streaming since it blocks out a region of the screen for your viewers, but a large number of streamers do include a small corner window that allows them to show their face as well. Some streaming services have a separate panel for the webcam. To set up your webcam or microphone with Streamlabs OBS, you first need to connect them to the PC and install their software. After installation, you can import them into any of the scenes within OBS. In case multiple such devices have been connected to your PC, you may select the device that you wish to use for streaming.

Theme

Streamlabs OBS allows you to select a broad theme as your overlay for the streaming session, which acts as a de facto user interface for your user. This is an important choice, which impacts the quality of the content that your users consume. Many gamers hastily choose the first theme they come across, not realizing the broad impact this choice can have. It is, hence, recommended that the choice of the theme be done prudently and with the experience of the user in mind. The theme of your game and your profile should be concordant, ideally relaying a coherent message through a banner.

Encoder

The settings of Streamlab must never be too high for the hardware that is hosting the stream, and too low to translate into a bad user experience. To change these settings, you can select the cogwheel in the lower-left corner in Streamlabs OBS, to take you to the Settings menu. First, navigate to the Output tab. Here, you can select two types of encoders - *software (x264)* and *hardware*. Depending on which hardware you have, you might be prompted to select a specific codec. For example, NVIDIA has *NVENC*. The software option will harness the power of your CPU to encode your live stream, while the hardware option will use your GPU. The general observation has been that the software option translates into better quality than the hardware option, as long as the load on the CPU through other applications is not very high. However, you can use the hardware options for low load games, since it does not tax your CPU as much. In case you still want to use your CPU, you can tinker with other settings to optimise performance.